

Ian Ranasinghe

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Location: Manchester, UK

Role: Product Designer / Full Stack Developer

Skills: Figma, React, Flutter, JavaScript, HTML & CSS.

UX/Product Designer & Builder with 5+ years experience delivering SaaS and government-backed platforms.

My non-traditional career path gives me a unique perspective on design and software. I've worked across industries, understanding tools and the people and workflows behind them in every form: software, hardware, and physical systems.

My portfolio includes government-backed projects like **Talk English** (led by Manchester City Council and supported by the Department for Communities and Local Government) and **Northcoders Learn to Code**, a platform I designed as both the first touchpoint for new students and a core system for delivering the bootcamp curriculum.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Stack

Founder, Product Designer & Developer

Nov 2024 – Present

- Designed and built Stack, a personal productivity app combining note-taking, task management, and AI assistance, available on iOS and Android.
- Launched first beta (51 users) and currently developing v2 with improved UX, AI-driven summarization, and semantic search via vector embeddings.
- Integrated OpenAI API for natural language tasks, summarization, and context-aware recommendations.
- Implemented Flutter frontend and Firebase backend, including Firestore, Authentication, and cloud functions for AI logic.
- Developed AI prompt strategies and vector store workflows for personalized, context-aware responses.
- Built and deployed landing page: [Stack](#).
- Experience spans end-to-end product ownership: UX/UI design, app development, backend architecture, AI integration, and user onboarding.

Northcoders

Lead Product Designer & Full Stack Software Engineer

Nov 2019 – Nov 2024

- **Northcoders Learn To Code Platform**
 - Designed from inception, creating a scalable design system that supports nationwide bootcamp delivery.
 - Built UX/UI for student onboarding, assessment, interactive learning modules, and ga mentor/admin dashboards—core to delivering all bootcamp content.
 - [Northcoders L2C](#)

Led end-to-end design for external client products:

- **Talk English**

- Designed learner and teacher interfaces for a government-backed language-learning app adopted by multiple councils (Manchester, Bradford, Wakefield).
- Focused on accessibility for adults with little or no English—using visual-first navigation, large tap targets, and offline support—while enabling tutor integration.
- Helped Northcoders secure the contract through design-led pitch, delivering a product that supports thousands of learners in building real-world language confidence.
- [Video Overview](#) | [Talk English](#)
- **Sparedesk**
 - Designed and delivered branding (including logo), UX, and UI for a flexible workspace marketplace connecting businesses and remote workers across the UK.
 - Collaborated with the founder to shape product vision, then translated requirements into a streamlined booking experience for listing and reserving desks, private offices, and meeting rooms.
 - Worked hands-on with engineers to ensure design fidelity through to production.
 - [sparedesk.io](#)
- **MST Systems**
 - Designed and delivered UX and UI for MST Systems, a strength training app created by elite coach Shane Jerman and trusted by world-class athletes, including Mark Felix and Lucy Underdown.
 - Developed flows for customizable programming, video-based learning, and progress tracking—supporting users from beginners to World's Strongest Man competitors.
 - Partnered with the founder to translate his vision into a scalable digital product, then worked closely with engineers to ensure implementation.
 - [App Store](#) | [Video](#)
- **Internal Learner Management System**
 - Led UX design for core internal platform used by tutors and operations teams to manage student progression and maintain compliance with Ofsted standards.
 - Collaborated directly with educators to design workflows for attendance tracking, grading, and learner support, improving efficiency and data accuracy.
- **Northcoders Jobs Board**
 - Designed and developed a jobs board to connect graduates with hiring partners, streamlining application and tracking processes.
 - Delivered responsive UI and intuitive navigation to enhance usability for both employers and students.
- **The Idol – Dorris**
 - Designed and co-developed a reusable chatbot builder for The Idol, the fintech platform powering major brands such as GoCompare, Compare the Market, and Legal & General.
 - Transformed an initial brief for a simple chatbot into a full visual CMS canvas for building and managing conversational flows, integrated with Dialogflow for Natural Language Processing.
 - Enabled non-technical editors to create, test, and deploy white-labeled chatbots without developer support, significantly reducing build time and scaling across multiple insurance products.
 - Initially hired as a Junior Engineer but pivoted to lead product design responsibilities due to team needs.
 - [Dev Incubator demo video](#)

Customer Advisor, later Active Management Team

Jun 2017 – Jul 2019

- Delivered front-line support for TV and broadband customers, ensuring high service quality.
- Participated in product feedback and user testing sessions for Sky Q and network products, gaining insight into large-scale UX processes.
- Identified pain points in customer service workflows and designed prototype solutions to reduce callbacks, submitting improvements to internal tool design.
- Learned best practices in enterprise tool UX, contrasting with previous experience of fragmented legacy systems (so much better than the co-op).

BuyAssociation

Digital Marketing Executive

Sep 2016 – Dec 2016

- Designed and coded marketing emails, managed CRM data, and optimized campaign performance.
- Created digital ads and website banners, applying brand consistency and visual design principles.
- First introduced to a/b testing and configuring pixels to generate sales
- Secured the role after creating a spec campaign for Aldi pitched to McCann, which led to a referral from a managing partner to BuyAssociation's leadership.
 - [Aldi Ad](#)

The Co-operative Bank

Customer Advisor

Jun 2016 – Sep 2016

- Delivered front-line support for personal banking customers while navigating complex internal systems.
- Worked in the blue pyramid
- Gained first-hand insight into enterprise software UX—observing fragmented, legacy tools and their impact on employee workflows.
- Observed large-scale brand and internal communication design across multiple sectors (banking, retail, and member services), gaining insight into how design operates at scale in a complex organization.
- Got to see the belly of a giant started by 28 working class folk

United Business Media

Recruitment Media Account Executive

Jan 2014 – Nov 2014

- Managed recruitment ad campaigns for clients across print and digital platforms, including leading design publications such as Building Design and Building.co.uk.
- Created visuals and layouts for job ads, building early expertise in design principles and brand alignment. (much more fun than cold calling to sell ad space to recruiters)
- Learned CMS workflows and digital publishing processes while collaborating with editorial and sales teams.
- Updated and managed website content, including ad placements, featured spots, and banner campaigns.
- Gained strong grounding in sales, client relations, and content strategy in a competitive B2B media environment.

Stellas Kitchen

Co-Founder

Oct 2012 – Nov 2013

- Learned how different it feels to sell something you've made.
- Co-designed and helped build the kitchen layout for operational efficiency in a small space.
- Operated a family-run Sri Lankan food business in a converted shipping container at Chester Lakes.
- Created the brand identity, including logo and menu design.
- Helped design the menu working with Mum whose cooking is superb.

Deva Heating and Plumbing

Labourer

Jan 2011 – Nov 2013

- Assisted with installations and repairs on domestic plumbing and heating projects.
- Worked on the house of a producer for Blue Planet, learned so much about design from her, her new house and everything in it was beautiful and told a story and I got to watch her restore it, her and the painters showed me a bar for art.
- Developed efficiency and prioritization skills working under a mentor managing multiple urgent client demands.

Lessgo Ltd

Founder (Non-technical)

Oct 2010 – Jun 2013

- Founded and led development of an early-stage travel platform targeting the 18–30 market, defining product vision and brand strategy.
- Built partnerships with major festivals including T in the Park and V Fest to drive early traction.
- Designed initial branding and UX prototypes; recruited a front-end developer to improve design execution.
- Managed budgeting and engaged consultancies for project scoping, gaining hands-on experience in cost modeling and vendor management.
- Learned critical lessons in fundraising and runway management after failing to secure capital—insights that shaped my approach to future product development.
- [Lessgo Ltd](#)

Mitchells & Butlers

Various Roles (Kitchen Porter, Waiter, Barman)

May 2010 – Jun 2013

- Delivered service across multiple roles, gaining deep understanding of customer experience and operational workflows.
- Learned how design in environment, layout, and presentation impacts user satisfaction and business performance.
- Observed large-scale brand revamp, developing insight into change management and standards implementation.
- Learned the art of culture in the workplace here.

Hugo Boss (Tessuti Group)

Sales Assistant

Dec 2007 – Aug 2010

- Gained first hand experience watching the owners family and my manager work closely to grow the business online.
- Observed high-level business strategy during expansion and acquisition (eventually sold to JD Sports).
- Delivered premium customer experiences and drove sales through expert client engagement and brand presentation.
- Supported new store launches, including event coordination, franchise compliance, and local business partnerships.
- I was like my managers Padawan (my manager being a master in service, good sales and fun at work).

Grosvenor Pulford Hotel and Spa

Waiter/Barman

May 2007 – Dec 2007

- Delivered high-end service at a luxury venue, sharpening communication and client management under pressure.
- Gained early insight into operational design by observing owners structure workflows and share friendship with staff for efficiency.
- Learned resilience and adaptability in high-stress kitchen environments, shaping a systems-thinking approach to problem-solving.

WHSmith

Sales Assistant

Sep 2006 – May 2007

- Built strong customer service foundations
- Learned how product presentation and diversification impacts sales.
- Handled retail duties including till operation and customer service.
- First experiences of groups of strangers coming together to work.

Robert Allsop (Private Estate)

Labourer

Jun 2005 – Jun 2011

- Learned to stay patient when solving messy problems.
- Learned the true importance of keeping workspaces tidy and functional.
- Saw how good design in a garage or smallholding makes life easier—everything had its place.
- As he got older, helped him deal with Parkinson's—lifting, supporting, he had a few falls where I was the first to find him.
- Helped with all sorts: cutting grass, walking dogs, cleaning cars, chopping logs and odd jobs around the estate.
- Assisted in his construction projects, joinery, and mechanical repairs.

Richard Vaughan Davies of Vaughan Davies (Mold Property)

Labourer

Jan 2004 – Oct 2004

- Helped my dad construct a wooden bridge from the owners house over the River Alyn to his car park.
- Learned the difference between using tools and using tools properly.

- Discovered the importance of well designed tools (like chain blocks!).

Chester Standard / Chronicle

Newspaper Delivery

Jun 2003 – Sep 2005

- Delivered newspapers.
- Sorted leaflets into newspapers.

Pierce Farms

Milk Delivery Assistant

Nov 2002 – Jun 2003

- 4am Starts.
- The owner Mrs Pierce always made time to speak to customers & ensured sweet coffee and buttery toast before each shift.

EDUCATION

Northcoders

Full Stack Software Development (JavaScript)

Jul 2019 – Oct 2020

West Cheshire College

Level 3 – Web Page Design

Jan 2010 – Mar 2010

Level 3 BTEC National Diploma – Business Studies

Sep 2007 – Jun 2009

Chartered Institute of Environmental Health

Level 2 – Food Safety in Catering

Sep 2007 – Aug 2008

Coleg Cambria (Yale College)

Level 3 BTEC National Diploma – Business Studies

Sep 2006 – May 2007

Bishop's Bluecoat C of E High School

Level 3 – Business Studies

Sep 2005 – Jun 2006

PORTFOLIO HIGHLIGHTS

- [Stack](#)
- [Northcoders Learn to Code Platform](#)
- [Talk English Platform – Video Overview](#)
- [Talk English](#)
- [Sparedesk Marketplace](#)

- [MST Systems App – App Store](#)
- [MST Systems App – Demo Video](#)
- [Chatbot Builder for The Idol – Dev incubator Demo](#)
- [Aldi Spec Ad](#)